

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 44

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: The narrator, the sole winter caretaker of a closed mountain hotel, describes her quiet routine and an unexpected guest.

1

The hotel sleeps from November to March, and I sleep in it. My job, on paper, is to keep the pipes from freezing, the roof from caving in, and the silence from doing whatever silence does when no one is listening to it. In practice, my job is to live alone in a building with forty-two beds, and to be sensible enough not to mind. I rise at six. I draw the heavy curtains in the lobby. I greet the empty armchairs as one might greet old colleagues — politely, by their own names, which I have given them.

2

My morning is a sequence of small, deliberate kindnesses to the building. I run the taps in each bathroom in turn, so that no pipe forgets what water is. I open and close every shutter, because shutters that are never moved seize up by February. I dust the long oak counter at reception, though no one will check it, because the wood deserves better than to be forgotten. At nine, I sit at the kitchen table with a pot of strong tea and the old wireless radio, and I listen to the weather report as solemnly as if it were a sermon.

3

The radio and I have an arrangement. I talk to it; it pretends not to hear. When the announcer says, with that brisk cheerfulness peculiar to weather forecasters, that there will be snow above eight hundred metres by evening, I say, “Yes, dear, we know,” and I refill my cup. When the news comes on, and a politician somewhere says something foolish, I tut at the radio as though the politician were standing in my kitchen and would, with luck, be embarrassed. It is, I admit, an eccentric habit. It is also the only conversation I shall have for three days, and I have grown to value it.

4

The afternoon of which I am writing was a Tuesday, in the second week of January, the sky already lowering by two o’clock. I had finished my rounds. I was peeling a single potato, with the unhurried

care of a woman who has nowhere else to be, when the brass bell at the front door rang. It rang once, then again, sharply. I put down the knife. In four winters at the hotel, the bell had rung exactly twice before, and both times it had been the postman delivering a parcel for the owner. This was not the postman's day.

5

The young woman on the step was caked in snow from her woollen hat to the buckles of her boots. Her cheeks were the alarming pink of cold rather than health. She had, she explained, set out from the village that morning to walk to the pass, and the snow had come down faster than the forecast had warned. Could she, she asked, very politely, please come inside for ten minutes to warm her hands, and would I be so kind as to point her back to the village road. She would, of course, leave again at once. I looked at her hands. They were the colour of putty. I told her to come in, and to take her boots off in the porch.

6

I did not, of course, send her back into the storm. I put her in the kitchen, which is the only warm room in winter, and I added two more potatoes to the pot. I gave her a pair of my own dry woollen socks, and a mug of the same strong tea I had been drinking since nine. We did not say a great deal at first. She watched the kettle. I watched her watch the kettle. After a while, when the colour had returned to her hands, she told me her name was Anya, that she was a student of geology, and that she had, very stupidly, come up the mountain alone. I said that I had heard of stupider things, and that the soup would be ready in twenty minutes.

7

We ate at the kitchen table, with the radio murmuring in the background and the snow making its small busy noises against the window. The meal was nothing — potato, leek, a heel of yesterday's bread, a square of hard cheese. Anya ate three bowls and apologised after each one. I told her not to be silly. I told her, also, that she would sleep in room 14 that night, which has the best mattress, and that she would walk down to the village in the morning with me, when the weather had settled. She thanked me very seriously, in the careful way that young people thank older women whom they do not quite know how to address.

8

She left at ten the next morning, in borrowed mittens, with a written note for her parents tucked into her coat. The hotel returned to itself: forty-two beds, one armchair I particularly like, one radio, one caretaker. I went back to my rounds. I ran the taps. I dusted the counter. At nine the following day, I sat down with my tea, and I told the radio, in some detail, about Anya. The radio, as is its way, pretended not to hear. But I think, all the same, that it listened.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says her job, “on paper”, is to keep the pipes from freezing and the roof from caving in. Explain, in your own words, what the phrase “on paper” suggests about the difference between her official duties and her real life at the hotel. [2]

2. The narrator says she greets “the empty armchairs as one might greet old colleagues.” What does this detail suggest about her character? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator describes her morning as “a sequence of small, deliberate kindnesses to the building.” Give **two** details from Paragraph 2 that show she treats the building with care and respect. [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The narrator says she listens to the weather report “as solemnly as if it were a sermon.” Explain how this comparison adds to our understanding of her routine. [2]

5. The narrator describes her habit of talking to the radio as “eccentric.”

(a) Why does she admit that the habit is eccentric? [1]

(b) Why, despite this, has she “grown to value it”? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. Give **one** piece of evidence from Paragraph 4 that suggests the ringing of the bell was unusual. [1]

From Paragraph 5

7. The narrator notices that Anya’s hands are “the colour of putty.” Explain what this detail tells the reader, and why it changes the narrator’s response. [2]

8. In Paragraph 5, Anya says she will “of course, leave again at once.” What does this suggest about Anya’s attitude on arrival? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. The narrator and Anya sit in silence for some time before they speak. Explain how the language in Paragraph 6 makes this silence feel **companionable** rather than awkward. Support your answer with **two** details from the paragraph. [3]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator describes the meal as “nothing — potato, leek, a heel of yesterday’s bread, a square of hard cheese.” What does the writer’s choice of the word “nothing”, followed by the list, suggest about the narrator’s view of what she has offered? [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article arguing that being bored may be good for the brain — and that we have forgotten how to be.

1

A quiet revolution is taking place in some of the world’s classrooms and clinics: adults are being told, with straight faces, that they ought to be more bored. The advice sounds eccentric, even faintly ridiculous, in an age that treats every empty minute as a problem to be solved. Yet a growing body of research suggests that unstructured, unstimulated time is not the enemy of productive thought but one of its most reliable allies. Boredom, it turns out, is not a hole in the day; it is the soil in which certain kinds of thinking grow.

2

The case begins in the laboratory. In a much-cited 2014 study at the University of Central Lancashire, participants who were asked to carry out a deliberately tedious task — copying numbers from a telephone directory — afterwards produced more original ideas in a standard creativity test than a control group who had skipped the boring task. Subsequent studies have produced similar findings. The mechanism, neuroscientists believe, lies in the brain’s “default mode network”, a system that becomes active when attention is not externally directed. It is in this drifting, half-aimless state that the brain appears to consolidate memories, knit together loose ideas, and rehearse plans for the future.

3

For most of human history, such drifting time was unavoidable. One queued for a bus, waited for a kettle, sat on a long train, walked home from school without anything in one’s ears. These were not glamorous moments, but they were, in their quiet way, productive: the mind, given no external stimulus, was forced to entertain itself. The modern smartphone has, in a single decade, abolished almost all of them. The average adult in a developed country now checks a phone more than ninety times a day. The micro-moments that used to belong to nothing in particular now belong, almost entirely, to a screen.

4

It is important to be precise about what has been lost. The issue is not screen time as such; a novel, a long letter, a thoughtful documentary can all be deeply restorative. The issue is the **quality** of the stimulation. A scrolling feed offers a continuous trickle of small rewards — a joke, a clip, an outraged headline — each engineered to hold attention for just long enough to deliver the next. This is not rest. It is mild, unending stimulation, and the brain that is given mild, unending stimulation never enters the wandering state in which it does its most quietly creative work.

5

Some schools and parents have begun, cautiously, to experiment. A small but growing number of secondary schools in Britain, Denmark and Singapore have introduced phone-free breaks, in which pupils are required to leave their devices in their lockers between lessons. Teachers report, at first, a kind of restless complaint, followed within a fortnight by something more interesting: pupils talking to one another, walking the corridors at a slower pace, occasionally — and this is the word teachers most often use — **daydreaming**. Parents who have introduced phone-free family meals describe a similar progression, beginning with sullen silence and ending, often, with the longest conversations the family has had in years.

6

There is, of course, no requirement that one’s life be organised by educational researchers. The same principles can be tested, gently, by anyone. Walk to the shop without earphones. Wait for the kettle without picking up the phone. Take a shower without a podcast. Spend ten minutes on the balcony, doing nothing, watching the traffic or the trees. The first few attempts will feel uncomfortable, even

mildly distressing — the brain, accustomed to constant input, will protest. By the end of a fortnight, most people who try this report a clearer head, better sleep, and the occasional surprising idea arriving from nowhere in the middle of a Tuesday afternoon.

7

None of this is a call to abandon technology, which has many uses, or to romanticise an age that had its own troubles. The point is more modest, and more practical. The brain, like the soil, has seasons of growth and seasons of fallow. To deny it the fallow time, in the name of constant productivity or constant amusement, is to risk a harvest that grows progressively thinner. A little boredom, properly understood, is not idleness. It is the empty corner of a room in which, given quiet enough, a useful thought can sit down at last and stretch out its legs.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that boredom “is not a hole in the day; it is the soil in which certain kinds of thinking grow.” Explain, in your own words, what this image suggests about boredom. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** things the brain appears to do when it is in the “drifting, half-aimless state”. [2]

14. What was the surprising result of the University of Central Lancashire study? Answer in your own words. [2]

From Paragraph 3

15. Why does the writer list activities such as queuing for a bus and waiting for a kettle? [2]

16. The writer says the smartphone has “abolished” most of these moments. What is the **effect** of using the word **abolished**? [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. The writer insists that “the issue is not screen time as such”. Why does he make this point at the start of Paragraph 4? [2]

18. Explain, in your own words, the difference the writer draws between **rest** and **mild, unending stimulation**. [2]

From Paragraph 5

19. Teachers describe pupils **daydreaming** after phone-free breaks were introduced. Why does the writer italicise the word **daydreaming**? [1]

From Paragraph 6

20. The writer says the first attempts to be deliberately bored will feel “mildly distressing.” Why might this be so? [1]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer compares the brain to “the soil”, with “seasons of growth and seasons of fallow.” Explain why this comparison is **effective**. [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **why unstructured, boring time is good for the brain**, and **what schools, parents and individuals can do about it**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Boredom appears to benefit the brain because ...

— END OF PAPER —